by hand. They are commonly called as the kagazi, a paper-thin variety.

The task of my company was to defend the assigned area along the LoC. For that we had to maintain an elaborate observation system to keep a watch all along the border. The daily routine on the post involved, besides the surveillance of the border, morning and evening 'stand-to', patrolling and the laying of ambushes to prevent intrusions, and the improvement and maintenance of our defence works. Occasionally, I would order stand-to or alert at odd times to test the readiness of my troops to get into battle positions quickly. Every morning, I would go around the company-defended locality and meet with the soldiers, and then attend to the administrative issues and some office work. Later, after lunch, I would play basketball or volleyball with the men. I got to know each of them well in a short time. Life was lonely as I was often the only officer on the piquet. There were no means of communication except the field cable and antiquated telephones for communicating within the battalion and with the units on our flanks. Letters were awaited eagerly and Rohini and I would write to each other regularly. But letters usually took longer than a week or even up to a fortnight to reach. Sometimes two or more letters would arrive at the same time, and it was fun to decide which one to open first.

Time passed and soon it was winter. In view of the heavy snowfall, troops on both sides of the LoC would keep a low profile. But I ensured that we never lowered our guard. In those days we had first-generation black-and-white televisions with the screens no bigger than today's laptops. We unfortunately couldn't receive the transmission of Doordarshan. Instead, we saw the Pakistani TV programmes. Their news bulletins were mere propaganda – India-bashing. But their plays were good and some English serials like *Star Trek* were absorbing. However, we did send a larger number of soldiers on leave during the winter. As the journey in transit from the rail head at Jammu to Tangdhar usually took over a week in the winter, the men were encouraged to avail of four months' leave at a time, for the current year and the following year as well, and thereby save time in movement.